

THE LIVING SAMURAI

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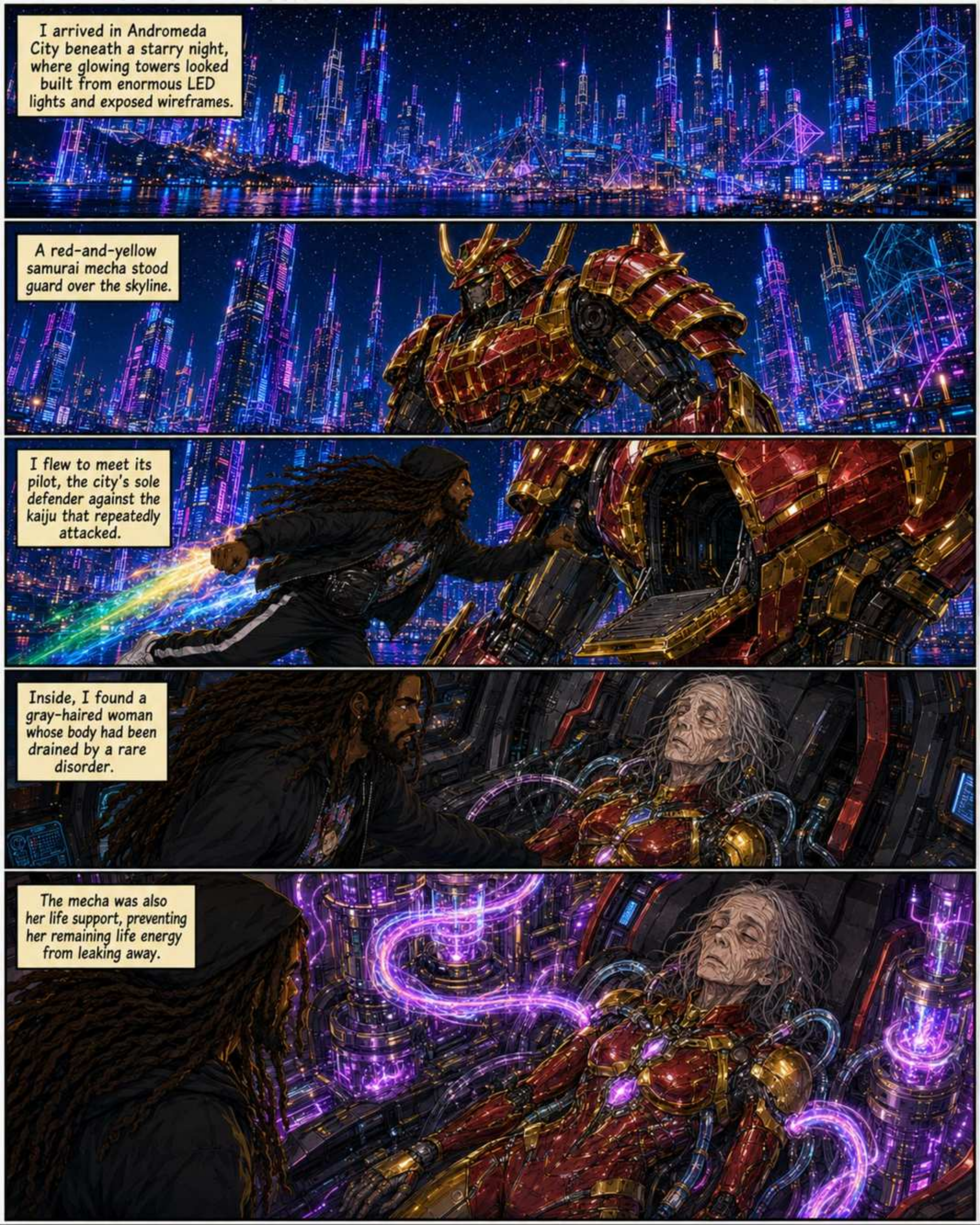
I arrived in Andromeda City beneath a starry night, where glowing towers looked built from enormous LED lights and exposed wireframes.

A red-and-yellow samurai mecha stood guard over the skyline.

I flew to meet its pilot, the city's sole defender against the kaiju that repeatedly attacked.

Inside, I found a gray-haired woman whose body had been drained by a rare disorder.

The mecha was also her life support, preventing her remaining life energy from leaking away.



I told her Silonis, the Rainbow Crystal Life Sword, could heal the damage done to her.



Before I could finish explaining, the mecha reached out to seize the blade.



A rainbow crystal force field repelled its hand.



She believed she needed the sword itself to survive and continue protecting the city.



I refused to surrender the Storyverse's most powerful artifact, but I promised to help her.



She was the only person capable of piloting the mecha, because the machine was bound to her.



Healing her body would free her from its life-support system, but not from the city's need for a guardian.



She feared that without the mecha, she would need Silonis to protect Andromeda City herself.



Her real wish was not simply to become young again.



She wanted a life that belonged to her.



I realized she had been trapped inside a false choice: sacrifice herself or abandon the city.



There was
another answer.

Silonis could restore
life, and I did not
need to choose only
one recipient.

I released a life-energy
slash broad enough to
strike both the pilot
and her machine.

The energy sealed
the leak draining
the woman's body
and restored her
youth.

At the same moment,
the empty mecha
awakened as an
independent living
being.



She emerged as a blonde woman with bluish-green eyes, wearing a metallic bodysuit that mirrored the mecha's red-and-yellow armor.



For the first time in her life, she stepped outside the machine.



The guardian no longer waited for her commands. It could think, move, and choose for itself.



She had expected healing to change her body.



Instead, Silonis had changed the meaning of her entire future.



Before either
of us could
celebrate, the
bay erupted.

A giant kaiju rose
from the water and
tore into Andromeda
City's glowing skyline.

The woman had spent
her life believing
only she could answer
such an attack.

Now the living
samurai moved before
anyone ordered it
to fight.

It charged across
the city and met
the kaiju with
its own will.

Andromeda City still
had a protector, but
its former pilot was
finally free.



The woman apologized for trying to steal Silonis. She had never imagined it could bring an inanimate machine to life.



Her desperation came from believing that survival, duty, and freedom could never exist together.



The awakened mecha chose to protect Andromeda City, while she chose what to do with the life returned to her.



I had not merely restored her youth.



I had given her life back.

